

Christmas. Beth lives less than two miles from her parents. (One of the proven ways that domineering parents control their adult children is by living close to them.) Ann reports there is some confusion about home ownership between Beth and her parents. It seems that Mother is always at Beth's—invited or not. And Mother was more involved with the choice of Beth's home than Beth was.

Beth married and became a mother before completing college. She and her husband lived with her parents for three years after they were married. This gave her husband an opportunity to complete college. Neither worked, even part time, during this period.

Beth's husband completed college and accepted an administrative position with a regional corporation, but after less than two years his position was eliminated. He then accepted a position as vice president of administration in his father-in-law's business. According to Ann, the vice president of administration was a newly titled position. The former title was office manager. But, as Ann explained, the job pays very well, and "you should get a load of the splendid fringe-benefit package."

It is difficult under such conditions for Beth and her husband to develop much self-confidence. Ann's parents, especially her father, do not show respect for Beth's husband. According to Ann, they always felt he was socially, economically, and intellectually Beth's inferior. They demonstrate much more respect for Ann's husband, who graduated with honors from a prestigious college and earned a master's degree with distinction at the age of twenty-four. Robert and Ruth constantly tell their friends and relations of the great accomplishments of "our Ann's husband."

Robert and Ruth rolled out the red carpet for Ann's future husband the first time he paid them a visit. They were very impressed with his academic credentials. Ann reported that during this brief stay, Beth's husband, then a boarder with his in-laws, acted much like a waiter. Father-in-law Robert would direct his son-in-law to mix and serve drinks and snacks, for example. After several cocktails one evening, Robert referred to his son-in-law as a "bozo." Ann and her beau were shocked. This treatment left a lasting impression on the couple. Ann pledged that she and her husband would never become "bozos" in her parents' eyes. To date, she has kept her pledge. This is the case even though Ann's parents pressure her unrelentingly to accept economic outpatient care. In contrast, Robert and Ruth regularly ask Beth's husband to do chores for them. They treat him more like a handyman and chauffeur than the man who married their older daughter.